

ROTARY ACTION
An LCH Prachand during its induction ceremony in Jodhpur

The operations in the high-altitude battlefield of Kargil in 1999 is vivid in the memory of Group Captain R.K. Narang (retd), a helicopter pilot. Most of all, he recalls how the absence of an attack helicopter had cost the Indian Army dear. When infantry units asked for close air support, Gp Capt. Narang, who was flying in Kargil, claims that the Indian Air Force's then-existing fleet of Russian-origin Mi25 and Mi-35 choppers were ineffective over the craggy terrain of Kargil and Drass because of their weight. "These choppers are heavy, meant for low-altitude operations and are supposed to carry combat troops." The Kargil experience led to an introspection within India's defence establishment, and designs for a Light Combat Helicopter (LCH) were first drawn up in 2003. The government sanctioned the indigenous LCH project in 2006, with state-owned Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd spearheading the effort. There were occasional setbacks, like the absence of some sophisticated infrastructure needed to develop such hardware, but progress was steady—over the next decade, extensive flight testing was carried out on four prototypes, and operational clearances came between 2017 and 2019.

In March, after the Cabinet Committee on Security gave its nod to the procurement of 15 Limited Series Production (LSP) LCH for Rs 3,887 crore along with allied infrastructure sanctions worth Rs 377 crore, the ball was set rolling. After 23 years, the Indian military finally got its coveted attack helicopter—a state-of-the-art machine named Prachand (fierce) that can operate at an altitude of 5,000 metres with a full load of weaponry. It can be a gamechanger for the Indian military. The first four Prachand helicopters were inducted into the IAF's 143 helicopter unit at a ceremony at Jodhpur airbase on October 3. After taking a sortie in a LCH, defence minister Rajnath Singh said, "There is no need to define Prachand. The message is received by the enemy." Prachand has nearly 45 per cent indigenous content by value, which will progressively increase to over 55 per cent, HAL claims. With the army and the IAF projected to require around 160 LCHs, HAL plans to step up production and deliver them within the next decade.

Weighing 5.8 tonnes, LCH Prachand is capable of operating in any terrain, weather or altitude, but is especially suitable for high-altitude operations. Extremely manoeuverable, it is capable of destroying enemy air defence and engaging in combat search and rescue and counter-insurgency operations. The sharpness it imparts to the IAF's combat prowess cannot be overstated. "It's a fast, agile machine. It charges clean through clear air turbulences (treacherous air masses). A lot of helicopters give up under such harsh weather conditions," says Gp Capt. Hari Nair, one of the lead project pilots of LCH. Nair's effusive assessment stems from the helicopter's performance over the Ladakh sector in winter, where pilots witness severe air turbulence, with windspeed up to 150 km.

A month after the Galwan clash, with tension at its peak between Indian and Chinese troops in eastern Ladakh, India deployed the LCH along with frontline fighters at Leh airbase. Stationing the aircraft in a live operational setting before it had been formally inducted was a remarkable signal. The fact that the indigenous chopper was pressed into service even before the US-made AH-64E